EXAMPLE 4.15

An object of mass m is projected from the ground with initial speed v_0.

Find the speed at height h.

Solution

Since the gravitational force is conservative; the total energy is conserved throughout the motion.

	Initial	Final
Kinetic energy	$\frac{1}{2}mv_0^2$	$\frac{1}{2}mv^2$
Potential energy	0	mgh
Total energy	$\frac{1}{2}mv_0^2 + 0 = \frac{1}{2}mv_0^2$	$\frac{1}{2}mv^2 + mgh$

Final values of potential energy, kinetic energy and total energy are measured at the height *h*.

By law of conservation of energy, the initial and final total energies are the same.

$$\frac{1}{2}mv_0^2 = \frac{1}{2}mv^2 + mgh$$

$$v_0^2 = v^2 + 2gh$$

$$v = \sqrt{v_0^2 - 2gh}$$

Note that in section (2.11.2) similar result is obtained using kinematic equation based on calculus method. However, calculation through energy conservation method is much easier than calculus method.

EXAMPLE 4.16

An object of mass 2 kg attached to a spring is moved to a distance $x = 10$ m from its equilibrium position. The spring constant $k = 1$ N m^{-1} and assume that the surface is frictionless.

(a) When the mass crosses the equilibrium position, what is the speed of the mass?

(b) What is the force that acts on the object when the mass crosses the equilibrium position and extremum position $x = \pm 10$ m.

Solution

(a) Since the spring force is a conservative force, the total energy is constant. At $x = 10$ m, the total energy is purely potential.

$$E = U = \frac{1}{2}kx^2 = \frac{1}{2}\times(1)\times(10)^2 = 50 \text{ J}$$

When the mass crosses the equilibrium position $(x = 0)$, the potential energy

$$U = \frac{1}{2}\times 1\times(0) = 0 \text{ J}$$

The entire energy is purely kinetic energy at this position.

$$E = KE = \frac{1}{2}mv^2 = 50\,\text{J}$$

The speed

$$v = \sqrt{\frac{2KE}{m}} = \sqrt{\frac{2\times 50}{2}} = \sqrt{50}\,ms^{-1} \approx 7.07\,ms^{-1}$$

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